

J.M.KAY • FOR DAVID WHITE • 9 SEPTEMBER 2026

Groundwork

Making the research method something a small team can run.

Two pages behind this. Three questions at the end. Everything else is decided.



“We have to just replicate ourselves.”

David White, on the drive, 20 August

The part that does not replicate yet

LARGELY PACKAGED

- Going to a market and getting the interviews
- Recording it, and filing it
- Closing a market out
- The instruments exist, they are blank, and they work

NOT WRITTEN DOWN ANYWHERE

- Turning verified evidence into a finding
- Turning a finding into something a client reads
- Not partially — not at all

One test: could somebody we hire next month pick this up and use it, with nobody to call. It splits cleanly, and not where I expected.

The proof is the thing you already named

“The single best thing. Circulating through the booth, advertising for Juno, and the reason the Adria calls stopped being contentious.”

His words, not mine.



It already ran.



It already changed somebody's temperature.



It is now packaged so a second person can run it.

And the second one is on screen

The morning dashboard you asked for on the drive is built.

One place, every market, what moved.

Every row is read from the record when the page is built. Nothing on it is typed.

The client is not named anywhere on it — a screenshot forwards.

I am going to open the real one now.

GROUNDWORK · FOR DAVID WHITE · INTERNAL

Where everything is •

"I'd love to have this comprehensive dashboard that I can go to in the morning, click on it, and basically see where everything is." — you, on the drive, 20 August

13
NEED YOU FIRST

3
DATED INSIDE A WEEK

0
DATES GONE PAST

30
CONVERSATIONS ON TAPE

Built 9 September 2026, 17:19 · every row on this page was read from the record at that moment. Nothing here is typed.
Each panel says underneath it which file it came from and when that file last changed.
The client is not named anywhere on this page — a screenshot forwards, so the labels say "the client".

What needs you

31 open on the register with your name on it. Priority and date as the register holds them — nothing re-ranked here.

Priority one and above

Has a date

Everything with your name on it

PB

Escalate A345 (interviewer disclosure) — HAM-2 is the fourth instance and the first inside a subject interview. On the Halli tape a Juno voice stated the narrative we were trying to disprove, called it "proven false", said "we love hearing these kinds of stories", and then supplied a percentage back to the subject. Add two lines to the Hamina field kit and the interview instrument before tomorrow: state the research question, never the desired answer; never repeat a figure back to a subject as established.
Aug 13 — before the next interview · shared with Jonathan / David · A377

PB

Ask Adria for Hamina's confirmed operational headcount — and say the ask has already been made once, from the Finnish side, and went unanswered. Cursor's managing director uses 500–600 with Finnish national politicians because he could not get a number: "I tried to get that from the client, for some reason. And I just don't see the point" (HAM-4 [32:44]).
Next Adria touchpoint · shared with Jonathan / David · A433

Your list, handed back

Ten things you committed to on the drives on 20 August. **Five now exist.**

- **Your morning dashboard**
- **The AI line for the Oracle proposal**
- **Ask for the bigger number up front**
- **Who absorbs the surprises**
- **Eight validated, two flagged — the claim audit**
- Speed as a priced deliverable
- Site community managers, early
- The stakeholder-category list
- Researcher names, and how we find more
- The educational repository

I went back through the tapes rather than my memory. The timecodes are in the plan.

What a new researcher gets on day one

Most of it already existed — it needed extracting rather than inventing.

Five blank instruments

The interview guide, as a fill-in

The evidence discipline

The citation grammar

Consent and compensation rules

A reference set of finished work

TWO THINGS ARE GENUINELY NEW

A market scaffold

One command stands up a new market's folders, its empty registers and the checks, and tells you whether it is ready.

The synthesis instruction

It does not exist. I am writing it, and I would rather show you one worked example than describe it.

The bench

- Juno hires them. I certify them.

You stay the employer of record and the commercial relationship. I stay on the standard rather than on payroll.

- Recruit tier one regionally.

Local fluency beats travel budget, and it is better for the work. A field journalist with diligence discipline — not an agency account person.

- The first hard market stays the two of us.

With somebody in the periphery watching and learning. A bench debuting in the hardest room we have had is a bad first outing for something we want to sell.

What it costs, and where the margin is

A per-market model rather than a rate card. Six lines, the budget model's own.

PLATFORM FEE

The instruments, the registers and the standards function; a band from the rate card.

RETAINER SHARE

My standing time across the market; a band from the rate card.

CERTIFIED-RESEARCHER DAYS

Researcher days per phase, at a day cost you set; you employ the bench, so those days are yours.

FIELD DAYS

The discovery and production visits, at a flat day rate from the rate card.

THIRD-PARTY LINES, BY KIND

Entered per market, never assumed.

CONTINGENCY

A fixed share of the lines above.

The budget model prices one market at the level of its ten phases, in four moves, against what a sourced research pass runs at today. The point of it is that your margin per market goes up, not down.

The sequence

1

Now to the end of the month

The kit gets blanked and dated.
Nothing needs you.

2

September is the field

Three trips, and I will shadow one candidate researcher under real conditions while I am already there. That is the certification pilot and it costs nothing extra.

3

Late September

The scaffold and one worked synthesis example get built.

4

Early October

One meeting. I will open with the dashboard on screen.

Nothing here needs a reply from you to keep moving.

If you say nothing until October, all of it still happens.

Three open questions

Each carries what I would do and what happens if we do nothing.

1

What is Juno's actual margin per market?

What I'd do. Give me a range rather than a number, and I will build the model against the bottom of it.

If we don't decide. I price against my own estimate, and we find out in October whether it eats your margin — which is the version where you quietly stop using the apparatus and neither of us says so.

2

Which market does the bench debut in, and how far in?

What I'd do. Debut them somewhere forgiving, apprenticing, and keep the hard market ours.

If we don't decide. We default to apprentice-only, which is the safe version and slower.

3

The name.

What I'd do. Leave it open until October and decide it with the positioning rather than before it.

If we don't decide. It stays Groundwork by inertia, which is how names get decided badly.

WHERE I WANT YOUR REDRAFT

Section six — the economics.



You did this with the interview guide in July and it came back better. You know what you can carry into a room and I am guessing at it.